

THE PUSHBACK Sanitation workers protest outside the Vidhana Soudha, Sept. 10

FIXING THE BASICS

Yet, mobility solutions are also Bengaluru's most contentious topic. Recently, the DKS government had to backtrack on an amendment to a 1975 law that would have freed up 5 per cent of the area of parks or gardens for public utility/ infra projects. The public outcry was centred around an iconic lung space, Lalbagh Botanical Gardens, under which a tunnel road was proposed. A pet project of the CM, planning for the 16.75 km north-south tunnel—connecting Hebbal and Sarjapura—was on for three years. Bids were called in December 2025; Adani Enterprises emerged as the lowest bidder at Rs 22,267 crore. But irate citizen groups and geological experts pointed to the damage it could pose to Lalbagh's ancient gneissic rock formation. The CM bowed to public opinion. Byre Gowda later said alternative routing alignments are being identified—while not omitting to pull up horticulture officials for the state of the city's green spaces, which are not free of garbage pile-ups either. His instinct is clearly oriented towards arriving at the ideal via the practical—working on actually existing conditions. He believes there's no way out for Bengaluru but to expand its mobility infrastructure: tunnels, flyovers are a key long-term part of this. He's also hoping to see the Metro rail network up from 96 km to about 170 km over the next two years. As relatively low-hanging fruit, the plan is to invest Rs 4,000-5,000 crore in the next six months on improving road surface quality across Bengaluru. Says V. Ravichandar, member, Brand Bengaluru Committee, which redrew the city's civic map and created the Greater Bengaluru Authority (GBA) in 2025: "The idea of GBA needed a strong political leader at the head, which Krishna Byre Gowda provides. Now, he has become the face of the city in a certain sense."

Meanwhile, Byre Gowda is going at the nitty-gritty with a vengeance. Up for public discussion, and being hotly debated now, are new vehicle parking rules. The recommendations include charging up to Rs 25,000 annually for parking on streets. 'Business as usual' is not an option that Byre Gowda considers. His focus is on making basic services work: an August 29 inspection revealed that 140 of 222 street lights on a key thoroughfare in central Bengaluru were not working. "By simply making systems work, you can bring about measurable improvement," he says. A conflictual edge is inevitable, and there he discovers his limits. On September 10, women sanitation workers—pourakarmikas—protested outside the Vidhana Soudha, insisting on an apology from him. In response to a plea by contractual pourakarmikas to be regularised, he recently highlighted a 30 per cent absenteeism. The statement was called "humiliating and anti-poor". The complexity of balancing his ideas with other perspectives and imperatives is something Byre Gowda is learning on the job.

That evolution is also enjoined upon the city's larger planning process and distribution of authority therein. The GBA, the nodal body over which Byre Gowda presides, completed a year of its existence on September 1. It was created by abolishing the old Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike, and splitting it into five city corporations that are coordinated by the GBA. However, the multiplicity of authority hasn't ended—for instance, land-use planning in the city as well as the entire metropolitan region were kept out of his remit and retained by DKS. A rational future model will call for integrated planning. For now, though, if Bengaluru loomed like a formidable mountain of problems, it has got its own urbane Dasrath Manjhi. ■

WHAT IS GBA?

- **The Greater Bengaluru Authority (GBA), created in September 2025 as a nodal body after erstwhile BBMP was split into five municipal corporations**
- **Head: D.K. Shivakumar, CM; co-chair: Krishna Byre Gowda**
- **The five-corporation structure has brought some decentralisation and more locally active administration. But municipal polls delayed, corporations without elected bodies**
- **The GBA's larger promise—effective coordination among multiple civic agencies—yet to fully materialise**
- **Bangalore Development Authority and Bengaluru Metropolitan Region Development Authority, responsible for land-use planning within the city and across the larger BMR respectively, were under DKS as Dy CM. The latter retains these two as CM**